

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1990-04-21

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

1 Ridván 1990

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

2 dearly loved f riends,

having ended a year of momentous achievements, we stand at the

3 threshold of the last decade of this radiant twentieth century facing an im-mediate future of immense challenges and dazzling prospects. The swiftness of events during the past year is indicative of the acceleration, as the hun-

4 dredth anniversary of bahá'u'lláh's Ascension approaches, of the spiritual

5 forces released with the advent of his revolutionizing mission. it is an accel-

6 eration which, in its suddenness and wide transformational impact on social

7 thought and on political entities, has aroused feelings of delight as to its

8 immediate effects and of bewilderment as to its real meaning and destined

9 outcome, prompting the astonished editors of an outstanding newspaper, finding themselves bereft of explanations, to attribute it to the workings of

an "i nvisible h and."89.6

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91 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

92 161for the followers of bahá'u'lláh throughout the world there can be no

93 doubt as to the divine Source and clear intention of these extraordinary

94 happenings. let us rejoice, therefore, in the wondrous signs of the benefi-

95 cence of god's abounding grace. The high level of teaching and enrollments

96 reported last riðván has been sustained, and new fields of teaching have

been opened from eastern europe to the china Sea. with the settlement

97 in recent weeks of two knights of bahá'u'lláh in Sakhalin island, the last

98 remaining territory named by Shoghi effendi in his Ten year global plan

99 entered the bahá'í fold. The recreation last riḡván of the local Spiritual
 100 Assembly of 'i shqábád, the recent election of that of cluj in romania, the
 101 first new Assembly in the "east bloc," the reestablishment and formation
 102 this riḡván of local Spiritual Assemblies in other parts of the Soviet union
 103 and in other countries of eastern europe—all these achievements and im-
 104 mediate prospects affirm our arrival at a significant milestone in the fourth
epoch of the formative Age. The Administrative order now embraces a
 105 community of wider diversity than ever before. it is such prodigious devel-
 106 opments that prompted our recent announcement of a subsidiary T wo year
Teaching plan, now formally launched, to which we commend your urgent
 107 and active attention.
how staggering, how far-reaching have been the activities which pro-
 108 pelled the community in one short year towards this stage in its evolution!
 109 As we reflect on the wonders of bahá'u'lláh's confirmations, our hearts turn
 110 with love and appreciation to the hands of the cause of god everywhere,
 111 who, as the standard-bearers of that community, have ever upheld its bright emblems
 against the darkness of the times. with an indomitable spirit they
 112 persevere in fulfilling, under all circumstances and wherever they may be,
 113 their god-given tasks to stimulate, edify, and advise its widely scattered,
 114 rapidly multiplying members. in the face of the new situation in the bahá'í
 115 world, we take joy in mentioning some instances in the past year of asso-ciation of
 hands of the cause with the developments in europe and Asia.
 116 Amatu'l-b ahá rúYíyyih khánum, in an extended journey to the far east,
 117 Spiritual Assembly of macau; spent time with the knight of bahá'u'lláh
 118 in mongolia where subsequently the first native declared her belief in
 119 bahá'u'lláh; and devoted much attention to the friends in different parts of
 120 the people's republic of china, where her film "The green light expedi-
 121 tion" has been shown on television. mr. collis featherstone focused much
 122 energy on reinvigorating the long-suffering friends in war-ravaged vietnam. 90.2
 90 3
 91 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

92 162At this very moment, mr. ‘Alí-Akbar furútan is visiting the uSSr, which
93 he was forced to leave during the persecution of the faith there; now he
94 has returned in triumphant fulfillment of a wish expressed to him by our
95 beloved g uardian some sixty years ago.

Nor have the counselor members of the international Teaching center

96 been slow in responding to opportunities to foster the climate of progress
97 now evident in all quarters of the globe. Through the unified vision of

growth to which they have called the continental boards of counselors

98 and their able, hardworking and self-sacrificing auxiliaries, a new vitality can be felt
in the expansion and consolidation of the faith throughout the

99 world. The continental counselors deserve the deep gratitude of the entire
100 bahá’í community as they approach the close of their current five-year term,
101 distinguished for their outstanding services.

102 just as the community has extended its ramifications internally, it has

103 also expanded its relations, influence and appeal externally in a variety of ways, some
astonishing in their breadth and potential. A few examples will suffice: Through the newly
established office of the environment, the

104 bahá’í international community, on its own initiative and in collabora-
105 tion with other environmental organizations, reinstituted the annual world
106 forestry charter gathering founded in 1945 by the renowned richard St.
107 barbe baker; since then the office of the environment has been invited
108 to participate in important events sponsored by international organiza-tions
concerned with environmental questions. The bahá’í international

109 community has been involved in the work of the Task force for literacy

under the aegis of uNeSco and was invited to participate in the world

110 conference on education for All held in Thailand, where its representa-
111 tive was asked to assume a variety of highly visible and important tasks which gave
prominence to the bahá’í community. Steps were taken, with
112 the encouragement of a fijian senior government official, to open in Suva
113 a branch of the bahá’í international community’s united Nations office
114 for the pacific region. The university of maryland in the united States
115 announced its decision to establish “The bahá’í chair for world peace” in

116 its center for international development and conflict management, which
117 will give rise to a great increase in academic efforts to examine the cause of
118 bahá'u'lláh. At almost the same time the National Spiritual Assembly of
119 india announced that an agreement had been reached to establish a chair

for bahá'í Studies at the university of indore.90.4

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91 1986–1992 • The Six Year Plan

92 16The continuing efforts to secure the emancipation of the bahá'ís of iran
93 evolved to a new stage. for the first time, a united Nations representa-
94 tive was able officially to meet on iranian soil with a representative of the
95 proscribed bahá'í community. The result was recorded in a report to the

united Nations commission on human rights, at whose recent session in

96 geneva a resolution on iran mentioning the bahá'ís was again adopted. in
97 a corollary action of far-reaching importance the united States house of
98 representatives unanimously adopted a resolution calling for the emancipa-
99 tion of the iranian bahá'í community and outlining steps to be taken by the
100 united States government towards this end; a similar resolution is before
101 the Senate.

102 in the holy land, preparations for the execution of the building projects
103 on mount carmel received a definite boost. it is a cause of deep satisfaction
104 that, on the eve of Naw-rúz, the district Town planning commission, after
105 delicate and complex negotiations, decided to approve the plan submitted
106 by the bahá'í world center. This paves the way for the ultimate issuance of
107 building permits.

108 beloved friends: merely two years separate us from the conclusion of the
109 Six year plan and the beginning at riḥvân 1992 of the holy year, that spe-
110 cial time when we shall pause to appreciate the tumultuous record of events which
will have brought us to the centenary of the Ascension of bahá'u'lláh

111 and to reflect with due solemnity upon the redemptive purpose of the life of the most
precious being ever to have drawn breath on this planet.

112 in anticipation of this high watermark in bahá'í history, plans have been

113 set in motion for two major world events: one, the gathering in the holy
 114 land of a wide representation of believers from around the globe to partici-pate in a
 befitting commemoration of that poignant consummation in the vicinity of the most holy
 Shrine. A component of this commemoration,
 115 symbolic of the transcendent and victorious influence of bahá'u'lláh's liber-
 116 ated Spirit, will be the depositing beneath the floor at the entrance door of his Shrine
 of a receptacle containing the illuminated roll of honor of the
 117 knights of bahá'u'lláh, a listing initiated by Shoghi effendi during his Ten
 118 year plan of those intrepid souls who arose to conquer in the Name of their
 119 lord virgin territories mentioned in that plan. This will have brought to a
 120 fitting conclusion, after nearly four decades, an intention expressed by the
 121 beloved guardian himself. The living knights of bahá'u'lláh will be invited

to witness this occurrence.90.6

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91 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 92 16The other event will be the bahá'í world congress to celebrate the cen-
 93 tennial of the inauguration of the covenant bequeathed to posterity by
 94 bahá'u'lláh as the sure means of safeguarding the unity and integrity of his

world-embracing order. it is to be convened in November 1992 in New

york, the place designated as the city of the covenant by him who is

its appointed center and who anticipated that "New york will become a

95 blessed spot from which the call to steadfastness in the covenant and Testa-
ment of g od will go forth to every part of the world."

96 related events at the local and national levels will combine with these

two primary occasions to give vent to the innermost sentiments of the

97 bahá'ís and to impress on the public the profound fact of the appearance in
 98 the world of the lord of the covenant and the aims and achievements of
 99 his sublime mission. indeed, plans are in progress to mount an intensive
 100 campaign to emblazon h is Name across the globe.

101 The friends everywhere must now orient themselves to the significances
 102 of these twin anniversaries. They must be spiritually prepared through
 103 prayer and study of the Teachings to obtain a deeper appreciation of the
 104 station and purpose of bahá'u'lláh and of the basic meaning of his mighty
 105 covenant. Such preparation is at the very core of their striving to effect a
 106 transformation in their individual and collective lives. let all the friends—
every man, woman and youth—demonstrate through the high quality of
 107 their inner life and private character, the unified spirit of their association
 108 one with another, the rectitude of their conduct in relation to all, and the excellence of
 their achievements, that they belong to a truly enlightened
 109 and exemplary community; that their best beloved, whose Ascension they
 110 will commemorate, had not suffered his life on earth in vain. let these
 111 requisites be the standard of their efforts to teach his cause, the hallmark
 112 of their homage to the king of kings.
 113 our dear and valued coworkers: it is at such a time of profound antici-
 114 pation for us that world society finds itself in a critical phase of its transition
 115 to the character envisioned for it by the lord of the Age. The winds of
 116 god rage on, upsetting old systems, adding impetus to the deep yearning
 117 for a new order in human affairs, and opening the way for the hoisting of the banner
 of bahá'u'lláh in lands from which it has hitherto been barred.
 118 The rapidity of the changes being wrought stirs up the expectations which
 119 inspire our dreams in the closing decade of the twentieth century. The situ-
ation is equally a bright portent and a weighty challenge.90.10

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91 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

92 165it is portentous of the profound change in the structure of present-day so-
 93 ciety which attainment to the lesser peace implies. hopeful as are the signs,
 94 we cannot forget that the dark passage of the Age of T ransition has not been
 95 fully traversed; it is as yet long, slippery and tortuous. for godlessness is rife,

96 materialism rampant. Nationalism and racism still work their treachery in men's
 hearts, and humanity remains blind to the spiritual foundations of

97 the solution to its economic woes. for the bahá'í community the situation

98 is a particular challenge, because time is running out and we have serious

99 commitments to keep. The most immediate of these are: one, to teach the

100 cause of god and build its divinely ordained institutions throughout the

world with wisdom, courage and urgency; and two, to complete on mount

101 carmel the construction of the Terraces of the Shrine of the báb and the

102 remaining buildings on the Arc of the world Administrative center of the

103 faith. The one calls for resolute, sustained and confident action on the part

104 of the individual believer. The other requires a liberal outpouring of funds. both are

intimately related.

105 over the last two years, almost one million souls entered the cause. The

106 increasing instances of entry by troops in different places contributed to that growth,

drawing attention to Shoghi effendi's vision which shapes our

107 perception of glorious future possibilities in the teaching field. for he has

108 asserted that the process of "entry by troops of peoples of divers nations and

109 races into the bahá'í world . . . will be the prelude to that long-awaited hour

110 when a mass conversion on the part of these same nations and races, and as

111 a direct result of a chain of events, momentous and possibly catastrophic in

112 nature, and which cannot as yet be even dimly visualized, will suddenly rev-

113 olutionize the fortunes of the faith, derange the equilibrium of the world,

114 and reinforce a thousandfold the numerical strength as well as the material power

and the spiritual authority of the faith of bahá'u'lláh."

115 90-1 we have

116 every encouragement to believe that large-scale enrollments will expand,

117 involving village after village, town after town, from one country to another.

118 however, it is not for us to wait passively for the ultimate fulfillment of

119 Shoghi effendi's vision. we few, placing our whole trust in the providence

120 of god and regarding as a divine privilege the challenges which face us,

121 must proceed to victory with the plans in hand.

122 90-1. cf , p. 117 .90.14

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91 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

92 166An expansion of thought and action in certain aspects of our work would

93 enhance our possibilities for success in meeting our aforementioned com-

94 mitments. Since change, ever more rapid change, is a constant characteristic

95 of life at this time, and since our growth, size and external relations demand much of
us, our community must be ready to adapt. in a sense this means

that the community must become more adept at accommodating a wide

96 range of actions without losing concentration on the primary objectives of

97 teaching, namely, expansion and consolidation. A unity in diversity of ac-tions is
called for, a condition in which different individuals will concentrate on different activities,
appreciating the salutary effect of the aggregate on

98 the growth and development of the faith, because each person cannot do

99 everything and all persons cannot do the same thing. This understanding is

important to the maturity which, by the many demands being made upon

100 it, the community is being forced to attain.

101 The order brought by bahá'u'lláh is intended to guide the progress and

102 resolve the problems of society. our numbers are as yet too small to effect an

103 adequate demonstration of the potentialities inherent in the administrative system we
are building, and the efficacy of this system will not be fully ap-

104 preciated without a vast expansion of our membership. with the prevailing

105 situation in the world the necessity to effect such a demonstration becomes more
compelling. it is all too obvious that even those who rail against the

106 defects of the old order, and would even tear it down, are themselves bereft of any
viable alternative to put in its place. Since the Administrative order

107 is designed to be a pattern for future society, the visibility of such a pattern

108 will be a signal of hope to those who despair.

109 Thus far, we have achieved a marvelous diversity in the large numbers of

110 ethnic groups represented in the faith, and everything should be done to

111 fortify it through larger enrollments from among groups already represented and the
attraction of members from groups not yet reached. however, there

112 is another category of diversity which must be built up and without which

113 the cause will not be able adequately to meet the challenges being thrust

114 upon it. its membership, regardless of ethnic variety, needs now to embrace
115 increasing numbers of people of capacity, including persons of accomplish-ment and
prominence in the various fields of human endeavor. enrolling
116 significant numbers of such persons is an indispensable aspect of teaching
117 the masses, an aspect which cannot any longer be neglected and which must
118 be consciously and deliberately incorporated into our teaching work, so as to broaden
its base and accelerate the process of entry by troops. So important 90.16

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91 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

92 167and timely is the need for action on this matter that we are impelled to call
93 upon continental counselors and National Spiritual Assemblies to devote
94 serious attention to it in their consultations and plans.

The affairs of mankind have reached a stage at which increasing calls

95 will be made upon our community to assist, through advice and practical measures,
in solving critical social problems. it is a service that we will gladly
96 render, but this means that our local and National Spiritual Assemblies
97 must adhere more scrupulously to principle. with increasing public atten-
98 tion being focused on the cause of god, it becomes imperative for bahá'í
99 institutions to improve their performance, through a closer identification
100 with the fundamental verities of the faith, through greater conformity to
101 the spirit and form of bahá'í administration and through a keener reliance
102 on the beneficial effects of proper consultation, so that the communities they guide
will reflect a pattern of life that will offer hope to the disillu-
103 sioned members of society.

104 That there are indications that the lesser peace cannot be too far dis-
105 tant, that the local and national institutions of the Administrative order

106 are growing steadily in experience and influence, that the plans for the construction
of the remaining administrative edifices on the Arc are in an advanced stage—that these
hopeful conditions make more discernible the shaping of the dynamic synchronization
envisaged by Shoghi effendi, no

107 honest observer can deny.

108 As a community clearly in the vanguard of the constructive forces at work

109 on the planet, and as one which has access to proven knowledge, let us be
110 about our father's business. he will, from his glorious retreats on high,
111 release liberal effusions of his grace upon our humble efforts, astonishing us
112 with the incalculable victories of his conquering power. it is for the unceas-
113 ing blessings of such a father that we shall continue to supplicate on behalf
114 of each and every one of you at the Sacred Threshold.

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91 m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

92 16891

Commencement of Work on Extension of Terraces

on Mount Carmel

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]